

Nationalist aspirations

Nowhere were the conflicting impulses of nationalism more tangled than in the Hapsburg Austrian Empire, an immense patchwork of ethnic groups across Central Europe under the nominal rule of Vienna. In 1867, following Austria's defeat by Prussia the previous year, Hungary was able to secure almost complete independence from Austria. The "dual-monarchy" that resulted—the Austrian Empire, now the Austro-Hungarian Empire—not only greatly boosted an assertive sense of Hungarian self-identity but also secured Hungary significant territorial concessions from Vienna, notably in Transylvania and Croatia. Yet whatever the continuing tensions between Austria and Hungary, the two warily preferred to remain united precisely for fear of further nationalist agitations from their own splintered ethnic populations. The Hungarians, for example, were notably reluctant to concede the kind of political rights they demanded for themselves to their substantial Slovak, Romanian, and Serb populations. At the same time, waning Ottoman control of the Balkans also encouraged nationalist aspirations—Serbia, for example, had emerged as a more or less independent state as early as 1817. Wallachia and Moldavia, essentially modern Romania, could lay similar claims

to independence by 1829. The Greeks, portraying themselves as the legatees of ancient Greek civilization, a role that won them support from liberals across Europe, had secured their independence by 1830 after a nine-year war.

Both Austria and Russia competed to fill the void left by the Ottomans. Austria's provocative occupation of Bosnia in 1878, which it peremptorily annexed in 1908, would create tensions that led directly to the outbreak of World War I in 1914. The Balkan Wars of 1912–1913—in effect a bitter squabble for supremacy between Serbia, Bulgaria, and Greece—were further evidence of the destabilizing effect of nationalist-driven state building.

The consequences

The notion that social justice could be secured by peoples pursuing the right to self-determination would rarely be realized in the 1800s—Vienna would continue to rule over its multi-ethnic empire until its defeat at the end of World War I in 1918, for example. Likewise, the people of Poland were denied any means of exercising such nationalistic rights to self-determination. And the Jews of Europe remained persistently oppressed, whatever the promise of Zionism from the 1890s to create a Jewish nation in the Holy Land. ■

Otto von Bismarck



Minister-president of Prussia from 1862 and chancellor of Germany 1871–1890, Otto von Bismarck (1815–1898),

also known as the Iron Chancellor, towered over continental Europe after engineering the unification of Germany. Bismarck's main goals were to ensure Prussian leadership of the German world at the expense of Austria and to contain the threat of renewed French hostility. A supreme opportunist, despite starting three wars, in 1864, 1866, and 1870, Bismarck thereafter worked tirelessly to maintain the balance of power in Europe, a task in which, juggling competing interests,

he was remarkably successful. He committed Germany to a huge program of industrialization, oversaw the further growth of the German armed forces, and launched a program of colonization. Despite being socially conservative, Bismarck also introduced the world's first welfare system, though his motive was as much to outflank his socialist opponents as to protect the interests of German workers.